

FOR INTENDED PARENTS

Is Surrogacy Right For Me?

Everything you need to know before you make any decisions. Clear, honest answers – not a sales pitch.

"From hope to heartbeat to home."

Robyn Price

Executive Director, Canadian Surrogacy Options

In this field since I was four years old.

A note from Robyn

I grew up in this field. My mother Joanne founded Canadian Surrogacy Options in 1992, and I have been part of this world since I was four years old. I was an egg donor five times. I have sat across from hundreds of families at the very beginning of their journey – nervous, hopeful, overwhelmed, and full of questions.

This guide exists because most of those questions are the same ones. And most people deserve honest answers before they ever pick up the phone or book a consultation.

Nothing in here is a sales pitch. If you read this and decide surrogacy is not right for you, that is a completely valid outcome. My job is to make sure you have the real picture.

"From hope to heartbeat to home."

THE PROMISE WE MAKE TO EVERY FAMILY WE WORK WITH.
THIS GUIDE IS WHERE IT STARTS.

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What is surrogacy, really?

Surrogacy is an arrangement where a woman – the surrogate – carries a pregnancy on behalf of another person or couple – the intended parents (IPs). In Canada, surrogacy is legal and governed by the Assisted Human Reproduction Act.

There are two types:

- **Gestational surrogacy** – The surrogate has no genetic connection to the baby. The embryo is created from the intended parents' egg and sperm (or donor material) and transferred to the surrogate. This is the most common type in Canada.
- **Traditional surrogacy** – The surrogate's own egg is used. This is rare in Canada and involves more complex legal considerations.

In Canada, surrogacy is **altruistic**. This means surrogates cannot be paid a fee or wage for carrying – but they can and do receive reimbursement for all pregnancy-related expenses. This is an important distinction and one we will cover in detail.

KEY TERM

Intended Parents (IPs) – the person or couple whose child the surrogate is carrying.

KEY TERM

Gestational Carrier (GC) – another term for surrogate. No genetic link to the baby.

Who pursues surrogacy?

Surrogacy is not a last resort. It is a first choice for many families. Here are the most common reasons people come to us:

- Medical conditions that make pregnancy unsafe or impossible
- Recurrent pregnancy loss or failed IVF cycles
- Same-sex male couples building their family
- Single intended parents (male or female)
- Absence of a uterus (congenital or surgical)
- Medical advice against pregnancy due to health risks

There is no "right" reason to pursue surrogacy. If you need a surrogate to have a family, that is enough.

Are you emotionally ready?

This is the question most guides skip. Surrogacy is a journey that involves deep trust, patience, and the ability to share one of the most intimate experiences of your life with another person. It is beautiful and it is also hard.

Families who do best are those who go in with realistic expectations and a strong support system. A few honest questions worth sitting with:

- Are you comfortable with someone else carrying your baby?
- Can you handle uncertainty and longer timelines without unravelling?
- Do you have support around you – a partner, family, therapist?

- Are you prepared for the possibility that a match may not happen immediately?

How the process actually works

Here is the honest, plain-language version of how a Canadian surrogacy journey unfolds from start to finish.

1

Choose your agency

Your agency is your guide, your advocate, and your buffer. Take your time choosing. Ask hard questions. Read reviews. Talk to past clients. This relationship matters more than most people realise going in.

2

Complete intake and build your IP profile

You complete an intake process covering your medical history, preferences, and family background. Your agency builds a profile that will be shared with potential surrogate matches.

3

Surrogate matching

Your agency presents your profile to surrogates who meet your criteria. When there is a potential match, both parties review each other's profiles and agree to a meeting. Chemistry matters. You do not have to accept any match.

4

Legal agreements

Once matched, both parties obtain independent legal counsel. A surrogacy agreement is drafted and signed before any medical procedures begin. This protects everyone.

5

Medical process

Your surrogate undergoes medical screening and clearance at your fertility clinic. Once cleared, the embryo transfer takes place. Most families go through 1 to 3 transfer cycles.

6

Pregnancy

Your surrogate is pregnant. You stay connected throughout – appointments, updates, milestones. The level of involvement is agreed upon between you and your surrogate upfront.

7

Birth and legal parentage

You are present for the birth. Legal parentage is established through the courts – the process varies by province. Your agency and lawyer guide you through this.

Realistic timelines

One of the most common questions we hear: *How long will this take?* The honest answer is: it depends. Here is a realistic breakdown.

PHASE	TYPICAL TIMEFRAME	NOTES
Agency intake and profile	2 to 4 weeks	Faster if you are prepared
Surrogate matching	4 to 24 months	Varies widely by program tier
Legal agreements	4 to 8 weeks	Both parties need independent lawyers
Medical screening and transfer	1 to 3 months	Depends on clinic availability
Pregnancy	9 months	Standard
Legal parentage (birth order)	4 to 8 weeks post-birth	Province-dependent
Total (typical)	18 to 36 months	Priority programs can shorten this

THE HONEST TRUTH ABOUT WAIT TIMES

The single biggest factor in how long matching takes is the program you choose and how many surrogates your agency is actively recruiting. Ask any agency you speak to: *How many surrogates applied last month? How many are currently matched? How many are available?*

What does surrogacy cost in Canada?

This is the question that stops most families in their tracks. Canadian surrogacy is less expensive than the U.S. – but it is still a significant investment. Here is an honest breakdown.

COST CATEGORY	ESTIMATED RANGE	NOTES
Agency fee	\$9,500 to \$50,000+	Varies by program tier and agency
Surrogate expenses	\$25,000 to \$40,000	Reimbursement only – not a wage
Legal fees (both parties)	\$8,000 to \$15,000	Each party needs independent counsel
Fertility clinic / IVF	\$10,000 to \$25,000	Depends on clinic and number of cycles
Psychological screening	\$1,500 to \$3,000	Required for surrogate and IPs
Life and disability insurance	\$2,000 to \$5,000	For surrogate – highly recommended
Miscellaneous / contingency	\$5,000 to \$10,000	Travel, maternity clothing, etc.
Total estimate	\$60,000 to \$150,000 CAD	U.S. pathways run higher

IMPORTANT

Surrogate expenses are reimbursements for real costs – not a salary. Canadian law is clear on this distinction. Any agency suggesting otherwise is operating outside the law.

The legal landscape in Canada

Canada has a relatively clear legal framework for surrogacy – but there are important nuances, especially by province.

The Assisted Human Reproduction Act (AHRA)

- Altruistic surrogacy is legal. Commercial surrogacy (paying a fee) is not.
- Surrogates can be reimbursed for documented, pregnancy-related expenses.
- A surrogacy agreement must be in place before any medical procedures begin.
- Both the surrogate and intended parents must have independent legal counsel.

Provincial differences

PROVINCE	PRE-BIRTH ORDER?	NOTES
Ontario	Yes	Strong framework, commonly used
British Columbia	Yes	Clear parentage legislation
Alberta	Yes	Generally straightforward
Quebec	No	Surrogacy agreements not enforceable – use surrogate outside QC
Manitoba / Saskatchewan	Possible	Varies – legal advice essential
Atlantic provinces	Varies	Consult a surrogacy lawyer

QUEBEC NOTE

Because Quebec's Civil Code does not recognise surrogacy agreements as enforceable, families based in Quebec are strongly advised to work with a surrogate in another province and complete the embryo transfer at an Ontario or BC clinic. This is common practice and your agency should know how to coordinate it seamlessly.

How to choose the right agency

This section might be the most important one in this guide. The agency you choose will shape your entire experience. Here are the questions you should ask – and what to listen for in the answers.

How long have you been operating?

Experience matters in surrogacy. Agencies that have been through complications, difficult matches, and legal curveballs know how to handle them. Newer agencies may be fine – but ask about their team's experience, not just the company's age.

How many surrogates do you have actively applying each month?

This is the single best proxy for how long you will wait. If they can't answer this question specifically, that is a red flag.

What happens if my surrogate needs to withdraw?

It happens. Medical issues, family circumstances, personal reasons. A good agency has a clear policy and will re-match you at no additional agency fee.

Can I speak with past clients?

Any reputable agency should be able to connect you with past intended parents and surrogates who are willing to share their experience.

What is included in your fee - and what is not?

Get this in writing. Some agencies quote a low headline fee and charge for everything else separately. Understand the full picture before you sign.

How do you handle surrogate expenses and trust accounts?

Surrogate expenses should flow through a trust account managed by a lawyer, not directly through the agency. Ask who holds the funds and how expenses are approved.

Red flags to watch for

Not every agency operates ethically. Here are the warning signs that should give you pause.

Guaranteed match timelines

No agency can guarantee when you will be matched. Anyone who does is overpromising.

Pressure to sign quickly

A good agency will give you time to review, ask questions, and have a lawyer look at any agreement.

No independent legal counsel required

Both parties must have separate lawyers. If an agency tries to skip this step, walk away.

Vague expense policies

If you cannot get a clear explanation of how surrogate expenses are managed and approved, that is a problem.

No references available

If they cannot connect you with a single past client, ask yourself why.

Paying surrogates directly

All payments to a surrogate should flow through a legal trust account. Direct payments create legal and financial risk for everyone.

Before you move forward

Use this checklist to gauge where you are. There are no right or wrong answers – just honest ones.

☐ I understand that Canadian surrogacy is altruistic and surrogates are reimbursed, not paid.

☐ I am emotionally prepared for a process that may take 18 to 36 months.

☐ I have or am building the financial resources to cover \$60,000 to \$150,000 CAD.

☐ I am comfortable with another person carrying my baby and being present in my life during pregnancy.

☐ I have discussed surrogacy thoroughly with my partner, if applicable.

☐ I understand that failed transfers are possible and I have the resilience to continue.

☐ I am ready to work with a lawyer, a clinic, and an agency as a team.

☐ I have researched at least two or three agencies and asked hard questions.

☐ I know which province my surrogate would ideally be located in.

☐ I am ready to take the next step – at least to have a first conversation.

YOU'RE READY.

What comes *next.*

If you have read this guide and feel ready to take the next step – even just a first conversation – I would love to hear from you.

A 30-minute call with me is free. No pressure, no pitch. Just honest answers from someone who has been in this field her whole life and genuinely wants to help you figure out whether CSO is the right fit for your family.

[Book a free 30-minute call with Robyn](#)

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This guide is provided for informational purposes only and does not constitute legal or medical advice.

Always obtain independent legal counsel before entering into any surrogacy arrangement.